FUELLING AMBITIONS

Puri's return signals a welcome continuity. Oil production and green fuels remain a challenge

By M.G. ARUN

With Hardeep Singh Puri back at the helm of the petroleum ministry, the sector is expected to see a continuity in policy. The minister has already said that boosting domestic oil and gas production, promoting green hydrogen and increasing the use of ethanol will be key priorities for the government. He was also quick to add that profitable PSU oil companies like BPCL would not be divested, signalling that the Modi government would like to stay clear of any controversy in the beginning of its third term. He has reportedly hinted at bringing fuel under the purview of GST, although that seems like a far cry, and reducing fuel prices if crude falls sharply in the international market. ■

WHAT NEEDS TO BE DONE

BOOST OIL PRODUCTION

Incentivise private participation in India's oil and gas exploration and production through tax sops. The Centre also needs to reduce the compliance burden, simplify procedures and improve 'ease of doing business' to attract more investments in the sector

PROMOTE GREEN FUELS

Earlier this year, oil major ONGC received the ministry's nod to form a subsidiary company for its green energy and gas business. This is important both from the global point of view where there is a lot of thrust on green energy, as well as for ensuring a cleaner environment in the country at a time when the vehicle population of the country has been increasing at a rapid pace

REDUCE FUEL PRICES

Voters across the country indicated with their ballot that high prices, especially of food, were an issue that the government needed to attend to immediately. To the extent that it can, the Centre can look at reducing fuel prices, especially if they fall in the international market. This will give immediate relief to consumers as high fuel prices have a cascading effect on the prices of goods

HARDEEP SINGH PURI, 72 | BJP
Minister of Petroleum & Natural Gas

↘ **FULL TANK** A former IFS officer, Puri took charge of the oil ministry in July 2021 when the country was still in the grip of the pandemic. He is credited with steering the sector through a stretched global energy crisis born out of a huge oil demand spurt when the economies recovered from Covid. The country also negotiated cheap oil from Russia after the Ukraine invasion, resisting international pressure to not do so



CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

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